



LESSON 2:TEEN BRAIN REFLECTION

Understanding adolescent decision-making

 **In this activity, you will** learn how your brain changes during your teenage years. You will then **answer questions** about how these changes affect the choices you make every day.



UNDERSTANDING YOUR GROWING BRAIN

Your brain is like a computer that is undergoing a major **upgrade**. Even though it might look fully grown on the outside, the inside is busy building new connections and pruning away parts that are not needed. This process helps your brain become more **efficient** as you move toward adulthood.

Concept	Explanation
Adolescence	The life stage between childhood and adulthood where the brain changes rapidly.
Development	The process of growth and refinement in brain structure and function.
Decision-making	The ability to choose between different actions based on logic and potential outcomes.



READ THE FOLLOWING TEXT

Read the passage below carefully. As you read, **ask yourself**: How do the physical changes in my brain shape the way I act or react in difficult situations?

The human brain does not stop growing when you turn ten. In fact, during adolescence, the brain undergoes a massive remodeling project. One major change happens in the **prefrontal cortex**, which is the area behind your forehead. This part of the brain is the 'command center' responsible for planning, organizing, and controlling impulses. During your teen years, this area is still under construction.

While the command center is still building, the emotional center of the brain—the **amygdala**—is already very active. This can create a 'mismatch' where emotions feel very intense, but the ability to control those feelings or think about long-term consequences is still developing. Because this connection between emotional intensity and logic is not fully matured, teens may sometimes take risks without fully thinking through the results.

Risky choices, like trying something dangerous or ignoring safety rules, can have a major impact. When you take a risk, you might get a quick feeling of excitement, but that choice could impact your **future goals**. For example, a decision made in a split second could affect your health, your grades, or the opportunities you have later in life. Learning to pause and let the 'command center' catch up with your emotions is a key skill for every student. By understanding that your brain is still developing, you can use that knowledge to make better, safer choices that support the person you want to become.



ANSWER THE QUESTIONS

Use the information from the reading passage to answer the questions below.

1. Based on the text, what specific part of the brain is responsible for planning and controlling impulses, and why is it important?

[Write your answer here.]

2. How does the 'mismatch' between the amygdala and the prefrontal cortex affect a teenager's decision-making process?

3. Why might a teenager find it difficult to stop and consider long-term consequences before making a choice?

4. According to the text, how can taking a risky choice today negatively impact your goals for the future?

5. In your own words, how can knowing that your brain is 'under construction' help you improve your daily decision-making?

